



AI Vendor Gaslighting Scorecard

7 questions. Every vendor meeting. Non-negotiable.

Use this before every AI vendor demo or procurement decision. A vendor who answers Q3, Q5, and Q7 in specifics has shipped. One who can't is selling the roadmap.

01

BEFORE THE DEMO

What round are you, and what does that mean right now?

Round labels no longer map to stage. 7 companies raised \$100M+ seed rounds in 2026. Ask what the capital is for, the runway, and what milestone unlocks the next raise.

FLAG

They pivot to valuation or investor names instead of answering.

02

BEFORE THE DEMO

Are you in the 2026 funding dataset — and does your raise match the public record?

Over 1,000 companies raised capital in 2026. Cross-reference their round, sector, and amount before the meeting. Discrepancies are a signal.

FLAG

They give a different figure than the public record.

03

DURING THE DEMO

You say "agentic" — what's your failure rate and what happens when the agent fails?

Over 110 companies in the 2026 dataset claim agentic capability. None share a standard failure-mode definition. Vendors who have shipped answer this in specifics.

FLAG

They redirect to a capability demo or say "it depends on the use case."

04

DURING THE DEMO

What benchmark did you use — and who ran it independently?

Benchmark laundering is endemic across 2026 AI raises. Internal evals on tasks you didn't request are not evidence of capability in your environment.

FLAG

Benchmark is internal, undated, or vs. a model not built for the same task.

05

DURING THE DEMO

Who in our specific vertical is a paying customer — not a design partner?

With over 500 AI companies raising in 2026, design partners are subsidised and non-representative. You need a paying customer in your sector willing to speak directly.

FLAG

They offer a design partner, a logo without a contact, or cite an NDA.

06

BEFORE SIGNING

What is your consolidation risk and what happens to our contract if you're acquired?

15 legal AI companies raised \$1.13B in 2026 — 2–3 will survive. Every AI sector is consolidating. Your contract must include data portability and change-of-control clauses.

FLAG

No portability clause, no termination rights on acquisition.

07

BEFORE SIGNING

Show me a workflow this replaced — not augmented — with a customer I can call.

Replacement is measurable. Augmentation is a productivity story. The difference between the two is the difference between real ROI and a vendor narrative.

FLAG

Every example is augmentation. No replacement case study with a live reference.

Scoring Guide

RED — Stop

Stop the evaluation. Ask the question again in writing. If still unanswered, walk away.

AMBER — Proceed with Conditions

Add protective clauses. Request a follow-up in 30 days.

TEAL — Lower Risk

Run your own pilot on your own data before signing a contract.